missiles out. Khrushchev's secrecy played into Kennedy's hands.

We know a surprising amount today about the inner history of the missile crisis. *The Kennedy Tapes: Inside the White House during the Cuban Missile Crisis* (Ernest R. May and Philip D. Zelikow, editors, 1997) supplies verbatim transcripts of deliberations within the American government. Alexander Fursenko and Timothy Naftali, *"One Hell of a Gamble": Khrushchev, Castro, and Kennedy, 1958–1964* (1997) draws on hitherto secret Soviet documents. James G. Blight's volumes of "critical oral history"—especially *On the Brink: Americans and Soviets Reexamine the Cuban Missile Crisis* (with David A. Welch, 1990) and *Cuba on the Brink: Castro, the Missile Crisis, and the Soviet Collapse* (with Bruce J. Allyn and David A. Welch, 1993)—contain the witness of American, Soviet, and Cuban participants.

This abundance of new testimony supplements and reinforces Robert Kennedy's account in *Thirteen Days*. The President was determined to get the nuclear missiles out of Cuba. American acquiescence in their deployment, Kennedy understood, would demonstrate the Soviet ability to act with impunity in the very heart of the American zone of vital interest. Soviet missiles in Cuba might not upset the strategic balance, but they would certainly upset the political balance and have a profoundly destabilizing effect on the world power equilibrium—not to mention their impact on domestic politics, never far from any presidential mind.

Kennedy, as his brother emphasized in *Thirteen Days*, was equally determined to get the missiles out peaceably. There is the theory that John and Robert Kennedy were "obsessed" with Castro and out to destroy him. If this had been the case, the deployment of Soviet nuclear missiles in Cuba would have provided a heaven-sent pretext—one that would have been accepted around the world—to invade Cuba and smash Castro forever. Instead Robert Kennedy led the fight against military intervention, and John Kennedy made the decision against it. Some obsession.

The President's purpose was to stop the delivery of further missiles through the naval "quarantine" of Cuba and to effect the removal of missiles already in Cuba through diplomacy. He took his negotiating credo from the British military analyst Basil Liddell Hart (whose book *Deterrent or Defense* he had reviewed in 1960): "Keep strong, if possible. In any case, keep cool. Have unlimited patience. Never corner